



This might change in the coming days, as Ajay Sharma, country head, HTC India, reveals: "We are proactively working on making the Android Market available on HTC's Android devices in India." However, we cannot help but feel that a golden chance has been missed.

A staggering price tag

As if the absence of the Android Market was not a big enough blow, the price tag of the device has come as a shock to many people. At Rs 29,990, the HTC Magic has been put in a category that is alongside the iPhone 3G and even above HTC's own Touch Diamond 2 (which boasts significantly superior specs), not to mention several Nokia, Samsung and BlackBerry smartphones. "Pricing depends upon a lot of factors apart from the operating system. We strive to price devices so that they offer value for money for our customers and justify the price tag that they carry. I think the HTC Magic certainly delivers on these counts," says Sharma, but a number of industry observers are not convinced that a device with relatively modest specifications and an open source operating system should be costing this much.

To make a comparison, HTC's own Touch Diamond 2 is priced at around Rs 29,500 and comes with a 5.0-megapixel camera and runs on Windows Mobile 6.1. Nokia's own flagship device, the N97, is available in the market for around Rs 33,000 and has a bigger touchscreen, a slide out QWERTY keypad, 32 GB onboard storage and a 5.0 mega-pixel camera. Samsung's Omnia is available for around Rs 26,000 and offers more storage and a better camera with Windows Mobile. Vinay Goel, country head, products, Google India, diplomatically stated that HTC must have had good reasons for its pricing of the HTC Magic, but added that phones running on operating systems like Android should logically be cheaper than their counterparts with similar specifications. "It is not just because the OS is free, but also the fact that as a phone

handset manufacturer, I do not have to necessarily write the device drivers for every component on my phone—they are all open source. So I save a lot on development costs. I do not have to go out and create a developer eco-system for this phone—it comes for free. There are so many things that come for free with this that a lot of the costs saved should, I think, be passed on to the user," he points out.

In his opinion, the best price point for a smartphone in a country like India is in the Rs 10,000-15,000 bracket—almost half that of the HTC Magic.

A missed opportunity?

It might sound harsh to say so, but given the absence of Android Market (at the time of writing, it still had not been made available for India's HTC Magic users) and the high price tag, the HTC Magic represents a missed opportunity for open source mobile OS in India. The very fact that one cannot at present download any applications to it, makes it inferior even to a run-of-the-mill Java phone on to which one can at least install some basic applications and games.

Even if it does get patched up to include access to the Android Market, it is doubtful whether the price-conscious Indian consumer will cough up close to Rs 30,000 for a device that, for all its excellent performance, still comes with relatively modest specifications. After all, even the iPhone struggled to make a dent in the official Indian market, although it raised a storm in the grey one, where it was priced considerably lower.

Mind you, it would be premature to write off Android or even the HTC Magic. Industry observers point out that handset prices tend to decline dramatically after their launch, and if the price of the HTC Magic were to slip to the more competitive Rs 22,000-25,000 range and HTC were to make Android Market (or an alternative download location) accessible on it, users might just start taking it more seriously. After all, it does have some very impressive hardware in combination with an excellent interface. Even if prices do not decline, there is every indication that the HTC Magic is just the first of the wave of Android phones that will hit India in the coming months, many of which will be at lower price points.

India's first taste of Android might not have been Magical (pun intended) but Google's mobile OS will definitely cast a spell in the days to come. **END** 

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